



Trump says voters must prove citizenship

Election experts doubt he has authority to mandate what’s in executive order

BY PATRICK MARLEY

President Donald Trump signed an executive order Tuesday requiring people to provide documents proving they are citizens when they register to vote, a mandate that experts said could prevent millions of Americans from voting.

The order reflects Trump’s long-standing fixation on election administration as well as his baseless claims following the 2016 and 2020 presidential races that both were riddled with fraud, particularly illegal voting by noncitizens. There is no evidence that widespread corruption, by noncitizens or others, tainted either contest.

Republicans in dozens of states have sought for decades to require voters to present identification to cast ballots, but Trump has taken that effort to a new level with an executive order establishing a federal mandate to provide proof of citizenship to register to vote.

The U.S. Constitution designates the power to regulate the “time, place and manner” of elections to the states, with the proviso that Congress can step in and override those laws. It gives no specific power to the president to do so. Election experts said that Trump was claiming power he does not have and that lawsuits over the measure were all but guaranteed.

“This executive order is unlawful,” said Wendy Weiser, vice president for democracy at the Brennan Center for Justice at New York University. “It’s a clear violation of the Constitution.”

SEE TRUMP ON A5



MAANSI SRIVASTAVA/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Director of National Intelligence Tulsi Gabbard and CIA Director John Ratcliffe, seen with FBI Director Kash Patel, were questioned about the Signal chat leak during a Senate Intelligence Committee hearing. **Story, A6**

Eagerness for secrecy is boosting Signal chat app

BY SHIRA OVIDE, DANIELLE ABRIL, AND HANNAH NATANSON

Days after Donald Trump took office, Jonathan Kamens realized he couldn’t speak freely in his two digital group chats with fellow government employees of the U.S. Digital Service. A friend cautioned that at least one of the group members might rat him out for warning the new administration would gut his agency.

So Kamens started inviting colleagues, one by one, to join him in a group chat on Signal, a messaging app known for its security

Growing popularity with officials, workers sparks fears for transparency

and privacy. Weeks later, and after being fired from his cybersecurity post, he is in eight private Signal groups with current and former federal workers, where they discuss who’s losing their jobs, trade messages of support and organize appeals to their firings.

“I’m not sure there is any

government worker right now who isn’t talking to their colleagues on Signal,” Kamens said.

Two months into the Trump administration, there’s a sweeping shift underway in Washington as federal workers — and some high-level administration officials — migrate their correspondence to Signal in a zeal for secrecy. On Monday, the Atlantic magazine’s top editor said he was accidentally added to a Signal group in which U.S. officials planned a recent military attack in Yemen.

Until now, Signal was mostly known among Silicon Valley

geeks and global dissidents for leaving few digital traces. It was lightly used among federal bureaucrats until they embraced it after Trump’s return to office as a tactic to shield communications, according to interviews with more than two dozen government officials. **SEE SIGNAL ON A7**

Hegseth: Chat disclosure puts new scrutiny on Pentagon chief. **A8**

Trump: President defends national security adviser after blunder. **A8**

Europe: Officials see messages as proof of U.S. scorn for allies. **A6**

Long waits, tons of calls: Social Security flailing

Musk’s cuts send agency into chaos as it awaits a new commissioner

BY LISA REIN AND HANNAH NATANSON

The Social Security Administration website crashed four times in 10 days this month because the servers were overloaded, blocking millions of retirees and disabled Americans from logging in to their online accounts. In the field, office managers have resorted to answering phones in place of receptionists because so many employees have been pushed out. Amid all this, the agency no longer has a system to monitor customer experience because that office was eliminated as part of the cost-cutting efforts led by Elon Musk.

And the phones keep ringing. And ringing.

The federal agency that delivers \$1.5 trillion a year in earned benefits to 73 million retired workers, their survivors, and poor and disabled Americans is engulfed in crisis — further undermining the already struggling organization’s ability to provide reliable and quick service to vulnerable customers, according to internal documents and more than two dozen current and former agency employees and officials, customers and others who

interact with Social Security. Financial services executive Frank Bisignano faced lawmakers Tuesday at a Senate confirmation hearing as President Donald Trump’s nominee to become the permanent commissioner. For now, the agency is run by a caretaker leader in his sixth week on the job who has raced to push out more than 12 percent of the staff of 57,000. He has conceded that the agency’s phone service “sucks” and acknowledged that Musk’s U.S. DOGE Service is really in charge, pushing a single-minded mission to find benefits fraud despite vast evidence that the problem is overstated.

The turmoil is leaving many retirees, disabled claimants, and legal immigrants needing Social Security cards with less access or shut out of the system altogether, according to those familiar with the problems.

“What’s going on is the destruction of the agency from the inside out, and it’s accelerating,” Sen. Angus King (I-Maine) said in an interview. “I have people approaching me all the time in their 70s and 80s, and they’re beside themselves. They don’t know what’s coming.”

King’s home state has the country’s oldest population. “What they’re doing now is unconscionable,” he said.

Leland Dudek, who became acting commissioner last month, said he was not a DOGE contact, senator says. **A4**

Hearing: Nominee falsely claimed no DOGE contacts, senator says. **A4**



ATUL LOKE/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Boys on a rooftop in Khoni, India, overlooking Palava City, which aims to have no emissions.

How to build a ‘net-zero’ city

In India, an entire community is designed to adapt to a warming planet

BY ALLYSON CHIU

PALAVA CITY, INDIA — The wind ruffled Aun Abdullah’s hair as he strolled along a path paved through lush grasses circled by apartments more than 20 stories high. Large gaps between the towering buildings channeled the winds, providing relief from the muggy heat.

“This breeze you’re feeling, you wouldn’t feel without the master plan,” said Abdullah, who works for the Lodha Group, a prominent real estate developer in India.

Abdullah’s company developed the layout of Palava City, a 5,000-acre experimental community northeast of Mumbai, to take advantage of India’s westerly winds. The breezes keep people cool outdoors so they can walk or bike instead of hopping into polluting cars and buses. The homes don’t need as much air conditioning. One study found that the development’s maximum temperature is consistently 2 to 3 degrees Celsius (3.6 to 5.4 degrees Fahrenheit) cooler than in nearby cities, including Mumbai.

SEE NET ZERO ON A12

Russia, Ukraine expand truce

BLACK SEA ADDED TO LIMITED CEASEFIRE

Nations divided on when it takes effect, execution

BY LIZZIE JOHNSON, SERHIY MORGUNOV, SIOBHÁN O’GRADY AND ROBYN DIXON

KYIV — Russia and Ukraine agreed Tuesday to expand their initial limited ceasefire on energy infrastructure to include the Black Sea after U.S.-sponsored indirect talks in Saudi Arabia.

In separate joint statements from the White House — one between the United States and Russia, another between the U.S. and Ukraine — the two countries agreed to “ensure safe navigation, eliminate the use of force, and prevent the use of commercial vessels for military purposes” in the Black Sea, as well as to develop measures to implement and monitor the partial ceasefire. The statements did not specify when the limited ceasefire would go into effect.

The statements — which came after this week’s technical talks in Riyadh, the Saudi capital — differed in two key ways. The U.S. separately agreed to help Russia gain access to world markets to export fertilizer and other agricultural products. For Ukraine, Washington reiterated its commitment to help facilitate the exchange of prisoners of war, civilian detainees and kidnapped children.

SEE UKRAINE ON A11

Peacekeeping force: Experts have doubts about possible mission. **A10**

Vaccine skeptic to head study on autism

Experts fear researcher, who pushed false claims, will produce flawed work

BY LENA H. SUN AND FENIT NIRAPPIL

A vaccine skeptic who has long promoted false claims about the connection between immunizations and autism has been tapped by the federal government to conduct a critical study of possible links between the two, according to current and former federal health officials.

The Department of Health and Human Services has hired David Geier to conduct the analysis, according to the officials, who spoke on the condition of anonymity for fear of retaliation. Geier and his father, Mark Geier, have published papers claiming vaccines increase the risk of autism, a theory that has been studied for decades and scientifically debunked.

David Geier was disciplined by Maryland regulators more than a decade ago for practicing medicine without a license. He is listed as a data analyst in the HHS employee directory.

SEE VACCINE ON A5

IN THE NEWS

Canceled funding Trump officials knew their legal justification for terminating dozens of EPA grants was flawed, documents show. **A3**

Crackdown on lawyers As President Donald Trump targets law firms that challenge him, some of his opponents are struggling to find attorneys willing to defend them. **A14**

THE NATION Trump officials refused to give a judge more details on controversial deportation flights. **A3**
GOP lawmakers face new pressure to pass tax laws and raise the nation’s debt limit. **A3**

THE WORLD Israeli strikes killed two journalists in Gaza, including a 23-year-old Al Jazeera reporter. **A10**
The head of Turkey’s opposition visited the jailed Istanbul mayor as protests continued. **A11**

THE ECONOMY As the legal battle over the firings of federal employees drags on, many affected workers are ramping up the job hunt in a difficult market. **A13**
23andMe sketched out a future in biotechnology and telehealth, but the company’s bets failed to pay off. **A13**

THE REGION Health officials reported that a person with a confirmed case of measles recently traveled around the District while contagious. **B1**
Waymo, owned by Google’s parent company, looks to roll out self-driving taxis in the District next year. **B1**

STYLE Karoline Leavitt, the White House press secretary, doesn’t hesitate to stir the pot with the press corps. **C1**
FOOD With omelets, like life, you eat your mistakes and move on, Jacques Pépin taught one Washington Post writer. **E1**

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